

Seal, explained

Sealed envelopes for the people you leave behind. A few pages, plain words, no jargon.

What it is, in one paragraph

Seal is an iPhone app. You write a few envelopes for the people you love: a letter, some photos, a voice message or a short video, and the practical things a family needs afterward, like passwords, where the will and the car title are, and who to call first. You hand small security keys to a few people you trust. You set a rule for how the envelopes open after you are gone. Then you just open the app now and then. Nobody, not Apple and not the people who made Seal, can open an envelope early.

A real example

A 58 year old man sits down on a Sunday night. He writes four envelopes. One to his wife with every password and where the documents are. One each to his two kids, just letters. One to his business partner with the login for the company website. He hands a key to his wife, one to his brother, and one to his lawyer. His rule: any two of those three, after 90 days of silence and three weeks of warnings. It takes him two hours. After that, the key holders do nothing for years. If he opens the app once during the warnings, everything stops.

The words we use

Envelope	Everything you wrote for one person: a letter, photos, a voice, a video, the secrets, and a short list of what to do first.
Key holder	Someone you handed a physical security key to. A key holder cannot read anything. Their key is one vote, and it only counts after a long silence.
The rule	How long you can go quiet, how long you are warned, and how many key holders must agree. You choose the numbers.
Check-in	Opening the app. That is all. It tells Seal you are still here. You can also say "Check in with Seal" to Siri or press the Action button.
Security key	A small key that plugs into or taps the phone. Sold by YubiKey and others for about 25 to 50 dollars. Face ID on the phone works too.

How it works, step by step

- 1.** You set up Seal with Face ID or a security key. This is your identity in the app.
- 2.** You meet each person face to face and add them in the app. It takes two minutes at the kitchen table. This is on purpose: the app trusts only people you have actually stood next to.
- 3.** You write an envelope for each of them. There is a guided set of questions if you do not know where to start. Nothing you write leaves your phone unlocked.
- 4.** You hand a key to the people you trust most and set your rule.
- 5.** You tap Seal. Everything is locked on your phone before it is stored.
- 6.** You open the app now and then. A widget on your lock screen shows "Last check-in: 12 days ago" so you do not forget.

What happens when the time comes

If you have not opened the app for the length of your rule, say 90 days, your key holders are told you have gone quiet. One of them can start a claim. You are then warned every day for three weeks, on your phone, and one open of the app stops all of it. A long hospital stay looks like death from the outside, and this is how Seal tells the two apart. After the warnings comes a quiet period. Then each key holder taps their key on their own phone. When enough of them have tapped, the envelopes open on the phones of the people they were written for. Your daughter reads her letter on her phone. Your wife sees the passwords, with a list at the top that says what to do first.

What Seal promises

Nobody can open an envelope early. Not a key holder alone, not Apple, not us. The math does not allow it, and it holds against the people who made the app too.

Stopping is easy, starting is hard. One open of the app by you beats everything. Starting needs a long silence, weeks of warnings, and several physical keys.

A key holder learns nothing. Not who the envelopes are for, not what is in them, not even how many there are.

The record outlives the company. Every key holder can save one file with the whole signed record. A small free script checks it with no Seal, no Apple, and no account. If the company disappears, the family is not stuck.

What Seal does not promise

That you are dead. Silence is silence. That is why there are warnings you can stop with one tap.

Everybody in the family. Today, every person who gets an envelope or holds a key needs an iPhone, needs Seal, and needs to have met you in person. A daughter on an Android phone in another state is a real gap, and we are working on an honest answer rather than a quick one.

A will. Seal is not a will and does not replace one. It is the letters, the passwords, where the papers are, and your voice. It sits beside the will.

Undoing a release. Once the envelopes open, they are open.

Questions people ask

Where are my letters stored?

Locked on your phone first, then a scrambled copy is stored with Apple's iCloud so the key holders' phones can reach it. Apple sees only scrambled data and has no way to unscramble it.

What if I lose my phone?

Your check-in stops, the same as if you went quiet. Sign in on a new phone with your security key or Face ID backup, and open the app. The warnings give you weeks to do this.

What if a key holder loses their key?

Nothing opens. That is the point of needing more than one. Hand them a new key and tap Seal again; it is free. Once a year the app asks each key holder to tap their key, so you find out early if one is in a box somewhere.

What if a key holder dies before me?

Same answer. Choose people likely to be reachable in ten years, and keep the number of keys needed lower than the number handed out.

Can my passwords go stale?

Yes, and the app knows it. Every six months it asks you to look them over. Saying "still right" costs nothing and does not need a new seal.

Does anyone at Seal read my envelopes?

No. We could not if we wanted to. The helper that suggests questions runs on your phone and sends nothing anywhere.

What does it cost?

The app is free to install. The person writing the envelopes pays once, \$29.99, the first time they seal. Key holders and the people receiving envelopes never pay. There is no subscription, because a sealed envelope that could break when a card expires would be a lie.

Why do we have to meet in person?

Because the whole product is trust, and a phone cannot prove who is on the other end of a text message. Two minutes at the same table is how the app knows your daughter is your daughter.

For a community or an elders program

Seal works best where people already gather. A community room, an elders program, a church hall: the in-person step that makes it hard for strangers is easy there. One evening with the keys on the table and the family present is the whole setup. A sponsor can cover the keys. A grandmother recording forty seconds in her own language for a grandchild is what this was built for. Nothing is held by a company, and the record stays with the people it belongs to.

How it works, with pictures: sealmessenger.com/how-it-works.html. The code and the verifier script: github.com/jasonepage/Seal. Questions: natepage67@gmail.com.